

BEST Established 1947

Standing true to its abbreviation, BEST ferries 45 lakh commuters in its 4,300 buses every day, even as it looks at beefing up its bottomline by renting out part of its 69 real estate properties

STAR SERVICE

As India celebrates 62 years of Independence, so does the Brihanmumbai Electric Supply & Transport (BEST) Undertaking. Started on August 7, 1947, today it transports an astounding 45 lakh Mumbaiers every day in its 4,300 bright red, London-esque buses. Originally set up as the Bombay Tramways Company, which provided transport service through horse-drawn tram cars, BEST was made part of the municipal corporation under the name of the Bombay Electric Supply & Tramways Company Limited by 1905. And in August 1947, the Company made way for the BEST Undertaking that imported most of its buses from England.

The first 'public' enterprise in India has seen several innovations over the last three years such as the

Equiphone tie-up, which means when a passenger switches on the Bluetooth, he can get the complete time-table of the bus routes. Mumbai will soon see 1,000 more state-of-the-art buses that will hit the roads in December, says Uttam Khobragade, general manager, BEST Undertaking. Of these, 200 are AC buses. He has introduced a number of reforms in his three-year tenure, with BEST benefiting from his IAS officer expertise.

It's not just the buses, BEST's 69 real estate properties are also adding to its annual turnover. For instance, the Oshiwara property has contributed Rs 224 crore in rent

to the undertaking. Similar properties including bus depots and terminals will be developed for commercial purposes and are likely to draw nearly Rs 10,000 crore. With the turnover of 2009-10 estimated to be Rs 4,500 crore, the annual profit is expected to be Rs 32 crore. "Looking at this trend, we will soon be able to turn around BEST's financial condition," says Khobragade. While most of the buses are still ill-equipped and overcrowded, the Starbus series with more room and air-conditioning in most is an impressive addition to

the fleet. BEST has also introduced a series of quality buses for schools and corporations such as Air India. About 30 per cent of the BEST buses now run on CNG, making them cheaper and more environment-friendly.

BEST, however, remains a security nightmare. Though spy cameras have been installed and 15 special

squads conduct random checking, this still remains inadequate. Despite the flaws, the undertaking truly embodies the always-on-the-go spirit of India. The ubiquitous BEST buses are as much a part of Mumbai as the ever-busy Mumbaier, standing rusty-red in the face of criticism and controversy.

33.14 lakh km

is India's total road network, which makes it the second largest in the world after the US.

"The challenge was to raise the standard of BEST travel and increase its annual income which had remained stagnant for decades."

Uttam Khobragade 57, General Manager

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